Dulles as head of the CIA in November 1961, informed key figures in the Kennedy administration about the CIA's recent findings. According to McCone's memo, twenty-one Soviet ships had reached Cuba in July and seventeen had either already docked or were en route to Cuba in August. Between four thousand and six thousand Soviets had arrived on the island in July alone. They were suspected to be military personnel, but as they were kept isolated from the Cuban population, that was not known for certain. The same applied to the equipment provided by the Soviets: the ships were unloaded in ports and areas cleared of locals. Nevertheless, the crates suggested airplane parts and missiles. Besides, there was clearly identifiable radar equipment. The CIA analysts indicated the possibility that the Soviets were placing surface-to-air missiles in Cuba.[15]

Robert Kennedy, McNamara, Rusk, and Bundy, who gathered on that day to discuss the progress of Operation Mongoose, were now faced with an entirely different situation. They turned the meeting into a brainstorming session on what should be done under the circumstances. The first option that came to mind was to stop the Soviet buildup by establishing a blockade of the island, either complete or limited to Soviet ships and those owned or leased by USSR satellites. That seemed to be a good idea with regard to Cuba, but Bundy, speaking on behalf of the White House, immediately put the brakes on it by pointing out the possible repercussions worldwide. He was concerned about the situation in Berlin. "It was felt," reads the CIA memorandum of the conversation, "that a blockade of Cuba would automatically bring about a blockade of Berlin."

With Berlin on their minds, the majority turned against the blockade option. McNamara proposed stepping up covert operations against the Castro regime. Robert Kennedy suggested a provocation including a staged Cuban attack on the Guantánamo base, providing a pretext for US intervention. McCone worried about such suggestions, noting the difficulty of conducting clandestine operations when security on the island was being tightened—the Castro regime was on the lookout for potential spies and saboteurs. But others in the room paid little attention to McCone's concerns. They felt that their hands were tied because of the situation in Berlin. It was agreed that McCone would report to Kennedy in person on the CIA findings.[16]